

Session 1: Introduction to Paul

Key Takeaways

- Paul's letters have influenced the world and shaped civilization.
- If Paul's words have become over-familiar to us, we can shift our focus and let his words become strange and new again as we learn more about Ephesians.

The Authorship of Paul's Letters

Placing Paul's letters in their first-century context will reshape our perception significantly.

1. **Letters had multiple authors.** The named co-senders of Paul's letters (Timothy, Sosthenes, Silas) were contributors to the content of the letters. They are named because they are co-authors, which means that Paul's letters contain material that is Pauline and non-Pauline, with Paul as the authorizing sender.
2. **Letters were compiled communally over time.** Paul's letters would have been created over periods of weeks and months in multiple stages and in group sessions with the named co-authors. They would have gathered in guest rooms, inns, and roadside stops, discussing and debating about how to word and arrange the letter.
3. **Material was employed in multiple contexts.** Teachers and writers carried notebooks (wax tablets in wood frames) where they would take notes, write down ideas and short paragraphs, and collect materials they could employ in multiple contexts.
4. **There are shared materials between letters.** Paul's letters contain preformed material from these notebooks, such as Hebrew Bible quotations, excerpts from early Christian hymns, teaching traditions, and sermon material that Paul had composed previously (the shared material between Colossians and Ephesians is a great example). This shows that many letters involved the editing and composition of preexisting material interwoven with new material written for the specific audience.
5. **Paul used a secretary to write his letters.** The skill set required to write these letters was highly specialized. Secretaries played a variety of roles from transcribing dictation to composing letters based on the sender's ideas. Paul's letters show a variety of practices.
6. **Letters went through multiple drafts.** Paul's letters certainly went through multiple drafts involving editing, re-wording, and re-ordering material until Paul was pleased with the final product (2 Corinthians is a great example).
7. **Letters became part of collections.** Paul would have retained copies of his letters kept in notebooks, and the growing collection provides a plausible context for the first set of publications of Paul's letters.

8. **Letters were expensive to produce.** Some of Paul's letters were much longer than a typical letter in his time (Romans, 1 and 2 Corinthians). Letters were very expensive to produce. In today's currency, the letter of 1 Corinthians would have required about \$2,300 to write and send.
9. **Letter carriers played a key role in a letter's reception.** They would have read the work aloud, explained difficult parts based on personal knowledge of the author's intentions, and answered questions from the recipient. Phoebe (for Romans), Eutuchus (for Ephesians), Epaphras (for Philippians), and Onesimus (for Colossians and Philemon) are among the named carriers.

Reflection Question

Describe your familiarity with the letters of Paul (Romans, 1-2 Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, 1-2 Thessalonians, 1-2 Timothy, Titus, and Philemon). What are some challenges you have faced when reading his letters? Maybe it's his use of language, cultural context, his teachings on women and slaves, or something else.